

Trauma and Trust

By Emeshe Amadé



At the heart of community lies trust—that soft and precious thing. It is the well from which relationship flows. Tended with care, it nurtures the ecosystem of community like fresh water. When the well runs dry, things wither. When the well is poisoned, when trust is betrayed, it can leave a lasting wound that leeches into the heart of a place.

We have all known betrayals of trust—moments small or large when our expectations of another were not met. It is rare to meet an adult who does not know that visceral feeling, that clench of the gut, that comes with misplaced trust. For trust is inherently vulnerable. It lives in our soft, white underbelly. It is young—deeply connected to the child we once were, that tender being who needed others to care for us. Given the right circumstances, we can heal, mature, and grow in our wisdom after such a betrayal. However, more often than not, we leave the wound untended, still oozing and raw, choosing instead to surround it with armor and cloak it in shame.

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Our community still suffers from years-old wounds left behind by a major traumatic event: the accusation of child sexual abuse against a once-trusted community member who is now gone. This event, which involved a dramatic arrest but ultimately no verdict or resolution, was a blade that cleanly sliced our community history into a before and an after.

It inflicted a wound that was beyond individuals' and the collective's capacity to cope, integrate, or process the shock and emotional distress. Many people chose to leave the community in the aftermath, while others stayed and continued with their lives, relying on time and personal journeys of healing to mend what was ruptured.

More than 50 percent of our current population arrived after the event, myself included. We have built on what those who stayed carried forth, and, although we are not the same as we were before, we are still a robust community doing our work in the world.

However, I sense that a trauma lingers—a sort of shame, or bitterness, or loss of trust

in our basic goodness, which continues to cast a shadow over our sense of self. Many see this event as a collective loss of innocence and optimism, a moment when our attitude shifted from “bad things can’t happen here” to “this place is like anywhere else.”

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These old wounds were reopened when, in February of 2026, my community discovered that another trusted, long-term member, who served as accountant to several of our internal organizations, embezzled a jaw-dropping sum of money over the last 10 years. Our books were in disarray, our vehicle sharing and infrastructure/maintenance co-ops were in precarious financial positions, and many roles of trust suddenly needed to be filled. Discovering we had been lied to shocked our ecosystem. Like a giant tree falling in a forest, it ripped up roots and dislodged soil—and in the clearing it left behind a terrible but familiar question: If we trusted you and you proved untrustworthy, can we trust anyone?

The wound was open; were we going to be able to tend to it this time? Were we going to heal from this betrayal of trust? Was this going to be the thing that finally broke us?

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It remains an unfolding process. Distress in the body turns into trauma when it cannot find an outlet, a drainage system. Since the energy will not simply vanish if ignored, it must be moved and transformed. This has proven true in my community's collective body as well.

The first thing we needed when the discovery was made was action, momentum, to feel that we were not helpless. In wilderness medicine they teach you to give your patient a job to do: can you hold this bandage on for me? Doing

something is empowering. It engages our agency and transfers energy away from victimhood. This situation called many of us into action. There was a niche for almost everyone who wanted to channel energy towards problem-solving, sense-making, or space-holding. At the end of our first emotional processing meeting, a powerful moment came when we were asked to make offers or requests to our community. Offers of dinners cooked, couches to vent on, free body work, and other simple but meaningful contributions poured in—the emotional energy of anger, sadness, and hurt transmuting into positive action for the benefit of the whole.

Then, of course, there was the question of justice. What will make us whole again? That's a challenging thing to explore with a group of almost 50 people. We shared an overarching value of accountability over revenge, and wanted a thorough process that matched repercussions with harm done. Still, different people were impacted differently by the event. Some community members felt they could heal their relationship to the member who stole the funds if he agreed to a repayment plan and worked to make amends with the community. Others felt too hurt and betrayed to want to continue to live closely with him. We each needed to consider what restorative justice meant in this context. Did it need to involve restoring connection to the person who caused harm?

In the words of Prentis Hemphill, "boundaries are the distance at which I can love you and me at the same time." In the end we decided that trying to reintegrate and rebuild trust with a community member who had broken it so badly would cause more harm to the community and some individuals within it than the potential healing it could bring to others. Sometimes an interpersonal wound is too deep to be healed from close up. It needs space, time, and proof of change before it can be reopened and cleaned.

We, too, identified a need to change. The holes in our systems, the ease with which they could be abused, were made clear to us. I have heard it said that as trust decreases in a community, rules increase. I believe this to be true. When trust is strong,

the need to legislate, regulate, and write things down is minimal. When trust weakens, being explicit, making the rule, creating the system of oversight, becomes necessary.

This is a tough pill for some of us to swallow. We want to live in a community where people do the right thing not because they are made to but because they recognize their interdependence with the whole and intrinsically wish to serve it. The honor system is easeful; it functions on the invisible wellspring of trust rather than the blocky, black letters of rules and policy. Systems that assume untrustworthiness feel suspiciously corporate, the opposite of the society we're trying to create. However, time has shown us that people can justify massive breaches of trust to themselves, even as they simultaneously wish to care for the whole. We know that humans falter, even if they are kind to us, or helpful, or bring integrity to some realms of their lives. Living in community shows us that we must contend with our wholeness, our shadows as well as our light.

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The questions that arise from situations like the ones my community has faced are not easily answered. How do we give people the opportunity to be their best selves, but also prepare for the moments when they are at their worst? How do we create systems which support trustworthiness rather than assume it? And how do we stay in relationship with one another with both openness and discernment; trusting not only what we hope is true, but what we have learned to be true?

I believe the healing of our community lies in our ability to continue to engage these questions and bring their answers into reality. When our nervous systems are reeling from betrayal, when our sense of trust and safety has been damaged, when our inner child is scared, we need an environment of improved safety to be able to rest, to ease out of fight or flight, to take a breath of relief. Without these conditions healing is impossible. Without them we continue to live in a state of fear, either suppressing and ignoring it or building defensive walls around the scared part of ourselves that is afraid to trust again. Yet, if they can be met, if we can find a path to being more boundaried and protected without falling into over-regulation or jaded suspicion, healing feels like a genuine possibility for my community. 🍂

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Photos by Emeshe Amadé

The Weight of Invisible Regulation: Trauma and Emotional Labour in Regenerative Culture

By Laura van Wijngaarden

Under the Covers

When I think about the theme of this issue, “Trauma and Healing,” I am taken back to the fall of 2023, five months after my second daughter was born. I remember hiding under the covers with my laptop while my baby lay nearby beside a music box. At the time, our community field often felt emotionally dysregulated, and I was trying to create safety through structure: cooking schedules, financial agreements, guidelines, and frameworks.

My body was exhausted from breastfeeding, sleep deprivation, and the emotional intensity around us. I could not yet see how deeply my nervous system had moved into survival mode through over-functioning, hyper-responsibility, emotional suppression, and constant management of the environment around me.

Writing this article has itself become part of the healing process for me. Naming what happened during the fall of 2023 asks me to speak more openly about the survival responses and relational tensions that emerged within it. I hope that sharing these experiences may help others recognize similar dynamics sooner, both in themselves and in the communities they are part of.

The Promise of Liminal Village

Liminal Village is an intentional community and regenerative living experiment in Central Italy exploring ecology, technology, and shared living. The project began primarily as a regenerative tech hub focused on systems change, collaboration, and alternative social and economic infrastructures. A core part of the experiment involved opening our home to a rotating flow of people exploring communal living, gift economy practices, regenerative projects, personal healing, and technological initiatives.

The constant flow of people brought inspiration, creativity, and meaningful connection. It also brought increasing emotional, relational, domestic, and organizational complexity. Much of the invisible labour required to hold the space together fell on me, shaped in part by deeply conditioned cultural and familial expectations around caregiving and responsibility that remain strongly embedded in Italian gender roles.

We had come to Italy after the birth of our first child in 2018. Our second daughter was born in 2023, just as Liminal Village was attracting more long-term residents and participants. That fall, several people were living with us, many carrying trauma histories. One came from a war-torn country shaped by genocide and decades of violence. Another had grown up in a neighbourhood affected by mafia violence, where bombs and explosions formed part of daily life.

I mention these histories not to locate the problem in particular individuals, but to illustrate that when trauma becomes activated in communal life, a group needs enough structure, maturity, protection, and repair capacity to metabolize what surfaces. We did not yet have that.

At the time, the emotional and relational dimensions of community life were often minimized or unconsciously avoided. Over time, I realized that no outer system can remain healthy or sustainable if the inner realities shaping it are left unaddressed. The inner lives of the people within a community inevitably shape the culture they create together.

Pseudo-Regeneration

The very values that drew us together—openness, inclusion, anti-domination, and trust in emergence—also made it difficult to set limits, step into clear authority, and intervene early when dynamics became unhealthy.

I began noticing a form of “pseudo-regeneration”: a gap between regenerative ideals and everyday behaviour. People spoke sincerely about collaboration, care, and mutual support, yet often struggled to embody those values consistently through accountability, conflict navigation, and shared responsibility.

Spiral Dynamics Green Values and Their Shadow Forms

How well-intended Spiral Dynamics Green community values can become destabilizing when not held by clear structure and boundaries

Green value	Shadow form
1 Inclusion	No clear limits
2 Harmony	Avoidance of conflict
3 Equality	Fear of roles or authority
4 Emotional openness	Emotional invasion
5 Anti-domination	Refusal of structure
6 Trust	Lack of accountability
7 Care	Over-accommodation

Open-hearted values can become shadow patterns when communities lack containment, role clarity, and accountability.

The gap between regenerative ideals and everyday behaviour seemed shaped both by nervous-system dysregulation and by privilege: an often unconscious expectation that others would absorb the emotional, practical, or relational consequences when commitments were not followed through on.

Pseudo-Harmony

One of the clearest patterns I observed within the community was a kind of “pseudo-harmony.” In a trauma-activated environment, keeping the peace can feel safer than naming what is wrong. Boundaries, authority, and direct conflict became subtly taboo in the name of inclusion, openness, and “good vibes.” Conflict did not disappear; it moved underground through tension, resentment, withdrawal, and side conversations.

Community can intensify trauma patterns by bringing nervous systems into much closer contact. Shared spaces, rhythms, money, and unresolved conflict reduce the distance people normally use to regulate themselves. Much of our communal life revolved around a very small kitchen where emotional intensity and unresolved tensions constantly collided. Without enough space or structures to process conflict, the closeness became overwhelming. Pseudo-harmony did not reduce conflict; it removed safe ways to address tension directly.

During this period, I experienced ongoing tension with another woman in the community who later recognized that she had been projecting unresolved wounds onto me. At the time, the dynamic was extremely intense. Because of childhood trauma and conditioning in my relationship with my mother, my nervous system experienced confrontation as threatening, and I struggled to address the conflict directly. Accommodation felt safer than conflict, even as the situation increasingly affected both me and my baby.

At one point, another community member commented on how much patience I seemed to have for the emotional intensity directed toward me. I remember thinking it was “not that bad.” Looking back, I can see how normalized the situation had become, and how deeply my nervous system had learned to minimize my own distress in order to avoid conflict.

My partner—cofounder of the project and father of our children—was also trying to preserve stability within the community. Because both of us were operating within ideals of openness, relational repair, and non-domination, neither of us intervened clearly enough to interrupt the escalating cycles of projection and conflict. Our shared difficulty in addressing tension directly allowed the situation to continue far too long.

Pseudo-harmony made it difficult to say: “This is too much. This person needs more support than we can offer. This dynamic is affecting the whole household. This mother and baby need protection. This experiment needs clearer boundaries.”

Green Shadow

In Spiral Dynamics language, I came to see pseudo-harmony as a shadow expression of “Green.” The values associated with Green—care, inclusion, openness, sensitivity, and anti-domination—are values I still deeply believe in. I do not want to live without them. But without enough maturity and self-awareness,

these values can become distorted: care turns into over-accommodation, inclusion into weak boundaries, and sensitivity into avoidance of necessary conflict. Power does not disappear; it becomes harder to see.

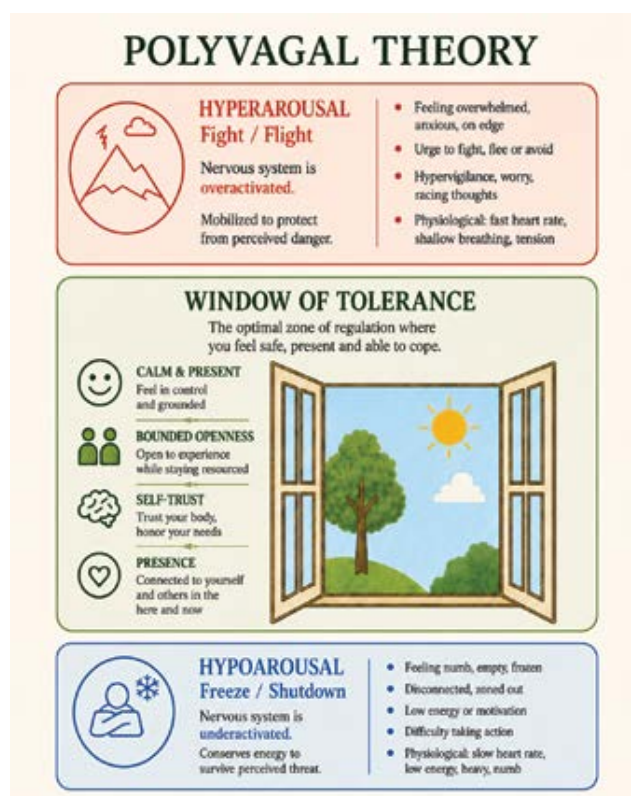
I often noticed a deep suspicion of authority, hierarchy, and structure within community experiments. That suspicion is understandable, since many people carry painful experiences with controlling families or institutions. But when structure is rejected entirely, power often moves underground through emotional dynamics, sexuality, unspoken roles, access to information, and caretaking patterns. Without enough transparency and accountability, these hidden power dynamics become difficult to interrupt.

The Nervous-System Cost for Mothers and Children

In the fall of 2023, I was breastfeeding a newborn. My body was shaped by the hormonal intensity of the postpartum period, with a nervous system biologically oriented toward responsiveness and connection. I was trying to learn the needs of a new human being whose nervous system was organizing itself through mine, while also responding to an unstable community field around us.

I had imagined early motherhood in community as a field of shared care. Instead, I spent long walks helping community members regulate while carrying my sleeping baby in a front carrier and listening to conflict, confusion, and pain. I was trying to stabilize the community while keeping my baby safe, fed, and loved, carrying responsibilities that were never fully mine to hold.

Trauma can reproduce itself in community not only through





overt conflict, but through the quiet transfer of emotional labour onto the people least able to step away. When communities lack enough structure, the burden of regulation often shifts onto the most attuned people in the room: women, mothers, founders, caregivers, and those who learned early in life to track the emotions of others in order to stay safe.

My daughter is now three years old, and while I cannot know exactly how that period shaped her, I feel it affected her. During that time, I noticed her holding tightly to milk, closeness, and soothing. I do not want to over-interpret those patterns—children naturally seek comfort in many ways—but I also cannot pretend that adult dysregulation remains contained within adults.

Babies do not live inside our philosophies. They absorb our nervous systems: our tension, presence, tone of voice and our ability to repair and reconnect. Trauma-informed communities must therefore include children, even when they are not part of formal meetings or decisions. Intentional communities create not only governance systems and ecological designs, but developmental environments.

Reclaiming Inner Priorities

After that intense period in the fall of 2023, I realized I needed to re-prioritize what was closest to me—much like in permaculture, where you tend first to the garden nearest your home. I shifted my attention toward my children, my health, and my home. Instead of continuously prioritizing visitors and community experiments, I began caring for the centre of the very ecosystem we were trying to create. This marked the beginning of healing for me. Like a damaged ecosystem, I needed less disturbance, more protection, and enough stability for regeneration to become possible.

I also began recognizing the trauma-shaped parts of myself: the “Good Girl” who feared disapproval, the part that equated disappointing others with danger, and the part that confused care with self-abandonment. As these patterns became more visible, I became more capable of regulating myself by observing my nervous system rather than automatically reacting from it. Healing began when those parts no longer ran the system from the background.

At first, my attempts to heal swung from over-openness and

over-accommodation toward the opposite extreme: closing off and limiting visitors in order to recover. This kind of pendulum movement is common after prolonged self-abandonment, as the nervous system often swings toward protection before finding balance again. I needed more quiet, distance, and stability before I could open again without immediately returning to hypervigilance and self-abandonment.

Through inner work, mentorship, rest, and time, I slowly became more able to remain within what trauma theory calls the “Window of Tolerance,” rather than swinging between hyper-arousal and shutdown. Polyvagal theory helped me understand these states as nervous-system responses: my body had been trying to protect me through mobilized anxiety, emotional over-functioning, numbness, and collapse. Mentorship became especially important because being supported and mirrored helped me rebuild a greater capacity for boundaries, presence, connection, and co-regulation.

Over time, my nervous system spent less time in survival states and more time in grounded presence, connection, and co-regulation. Healing did not remain individual; it began moving through our family system, which, for good and ill, sits at the core of Liminal Village. I noticed the effects of my healing journey on my children—especially my oldest daughter, now eight years old, whose nervous system became calmer as I became more present and less consumed by unspoken tensions.

Living Membranes

One of the realizations for me during these years at Liminal Village was that healthy communities need living membranes: clear and compassionate boundaries that regulate intensity, clarify responsibility, protect rest, and create conditions for healing. Trauma often deepens in environments marked by chronic ambiguity, overwhelm, or lack of containment. For me, living membranes include slower onboarding, clearer expectations, visible leadership, defined pathways for conflict, privacy, retreat space, and honest limits around what a community can and cannot hold.

I also came to understand that community is not only a social experiment among adults. It is an atmosphere that children live inside. Mothers, babies, and children cannot become secondary to the ideals of the experiment.

The lesson for me was not to abandon openness or care, but to recognize that healing requires structure, containment, accountability, and forms strong enough to hold vulnerability and conflict without collapsing into dysregulation. 🌱

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The Wounds We Bring With Us

Trauma Literacy, Response-Ability, and Regenerative Community Practice

By Jillian Hovey

Our understanding of trauma has been changing, and trauma literacy is part of that shift. Not so long ago, the word “trauma” was mostly used for intense experiences such as assault, sudden loss, disaster, violence, or war. Those experiences are sometimes called “Big T” traumas. Trauma literacy also recognizes “small t” traumas, which are cumulative or less visible harms woven through ordinary life. These can take the form of chronic stress, shame, neglect, emotional absence, boundary violations, or forms of cultural conditioning that teach us to disconnect from our needs, feelings, or truths.

Trauma can come from what happened. It can also form around *what did not happen*. That can include protection that did not arrive, repair that never came, dignity that was not protected, and belonging that never felt safe. Over time, what happened and what did not happen can shape how we understand life, protect ourselves, reach for connection, and move through the world. Trauma can form a kind of scar tissue, which can carry not only memories of pain, but also ways of protecting ourselves in relationship. We do not leave these histories at the door when we enter community.

The Wounds I Walk With

My family history includes intergenerational trauma involving childhood accidents and death, addiction, mental illness, repeated suicide attempts, narcissism, incest, and war. My family had enough money during most of my growing years, but very little capacity to be present and connect with my emotional and physical needs. That neglect contributed to a serious childhood accident that left me with lifelong physical challenges. My only sibling was born with mental and physical disabilities. I love her dearly, and I also recognize that the intensity of her care contributed significantly to my learning to go without much of what I needed. All of these factors have shaped how I understand myself, relate to others, and move through the world.

I started to wake up at age 16 when I recognized that some of the patterns I had inherited were not ones I wanted to keep living from. I have been on a path of learning, healing, and evolving ever since. More recently, my journey has included a multi-year trauma therapy program at Women’s College Hospital in Toronto for adults who experienced trauma in childhood. Their support has helped me meet deep-seated wounds and continue learning how the effects of trauma live in me and shape my relationships.

Community life has been part of my learning about trauma and healing since I first began living in community in 1983.

I saw early on how tensions and relational dynamics could arise between people. Over the decades since, I have had the privilege of supporting people and projects in over 40 countries across five continents. Living and working in community across diverse cultural contexts has helped me recognize how trauma-shaped patterns move through human groups. What I share here comes from that ongoing learning and practice.

Trauma Literacy and Intentional Community

Intentional communities have long been places where people are catalysts of cultural change. We experiment with how to share labour, make decisions, hold power, live with conflict, practice belonging, and care for land and one another. In many ways, intentional communities have already been practising trauma-relevant capacities, even before



The Fabric of Trauma shows how different kinds, sources, scales, and imprints of trauma become part of what we bring into community life.

we had trauma-specific language. Trauma literacy gives us a way to bring more conscious attention to that existing work. It can help communities work more skillfully with what is already happening within and between us, but trauma language should not become a way to avoid accountability, over-explain wounds, or label others. When held with care, increasing our trauma literacy can help us see the threads we carry and meet them with more discernment and responsibility. In community, these threads rarely stay private for long; they become part of the shared field.

The Ecology of Trauma and Protection

Through my own healing work, I have come to understand that the impact of trauma can extend beyond the initial wound. Dr. Gabor Maté, whose trauma work has become quite well known, helps deepen this understanding of trauma. Dr. Maté says trauma is not only the event itself, but what remains alive in us afterward. Those lasting effects can include needs that were not met, longings that did not feel safe, fears, meanings, and protective strategies. Together, they can form an inner ecology that influences how we perceive, respond, and relate.

Internal Family Systems (IFS) offers a helpful framework for understanding the relationship between wounds and their protectors. In the IFS model, human beings carry “wounded parts” that hold hurt, fear, shame, and unmet needs, and also “protective parts” that try to prevent that pain from being touched again. Protectors may act in familiar trauma responses such as fight, flight, freeze, or fawn. In daily interactions, those protective responses can take many forms, including control, criticism, withdrawal, appeasing, numbing, over-functioning, or caretaking. They are attempts to protect, even when their effects become painful.

Protectors often become part of our inner life, influencing how we perceive, relate, lead, avoid, defend, help, or stay safe. Many of us live from those protectors without realizing it. In fact, protective strategies can feel like personality, maturity, competence, discernment, independence, generosity, or simply “how I am.” They can also live in the body as tension, numbness, vigilance, impulse, collapse, or exhaustion. When something in the present touches an old wound, we may feel triggered. When that happens, protection can move at the lightning speed of the nervous system.

While protective strategies can have painful effects, they are not the enemy. IFS offers the reminder that there are “no bad parts.” Protectors often develop as intelligent ways of surviving, adapting, belonging, or preventing further harm. At the same time, strat-

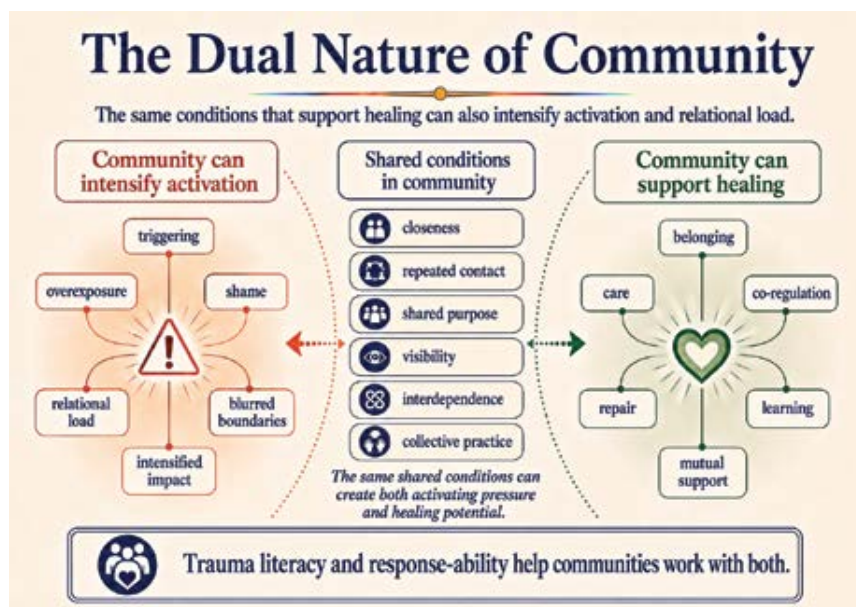
egies that once helped us try to stay safe can later make truth, feedback, intimacy, rest, or responsibility feel harder to bear. In personal growth and community practice, the invitation is not to shame these strategies, but to bring compassion and curiosity to them. We can ask what this protector is afraid of, what it is defending, and what support, safety, or choice might help it soften.

Relational Load and the Dual Nature of Community

I have often witnessed how one person’s protective strategies can affect the field of community life. Protective reactivity can teach a group which truths feel speakable, whose reactions need to be managed, and which impacts are safer to leave unspoken. When a community avoids naming and working with these protective patterns, invisible labour can accumulate and resentment can build around unmet needs. Silence can be mistaken for harmony when the people most affected have learned that speaking up costs too much. Close living makes those dynamics harder to contain as private.

The term *relational load* names the pressure that builds when life in community concentrates emotional needs, practical responsibilities, unspoken impacts, and unresolved tensions. Conventional life often separates work, friendship, family, housing, money, and governance into different spheres. In community, feedback, meals, tools, money, leadership, belonging, and daily logistics have much more overlap. People rely more directly on each other and feel the effects of others’ choices more immediately. Relational load matters because concentrated contact can intensify protective activation and make ordinary interactions more consequential.

Relational load brings activation and healing potential closer together. Belonging can touch old grief, a request for accountability may stir shame, a boundary can awaken fear of abandonment, and a leadership gap can pull people into over-functioning. Those moments can become painful when protective reactions are ignored, indulged, or left to organize the group. Contact, visibility, and interdependence can also offer more mirrors,



Community can support healing and intensify activation through the same closeness, visibility, interdependence, and daily life together.